

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ALGERIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Algeria turns above all on water in a land that is mostly desert, and on the extraction that threatens it. This is a vast, largely Saharan nation, one of the world's great gas exporters, whose people in the south depend almost entirely on a finite fossil aquifer beneath the sand, and whose government has pressed shale-gas fracking into that same desert — a pursuit that once drew, from the oasis town of In Salah, one of the most remarkable community environmental mobilisations the country has seen. That confrontation — between the extraction of the Sahara's gas and the protection of its scarce and irreplaceable water, and the community stand it provoked — is the distinctive ground of environmental effort here, because it showed that even in a semi-closed state, a community defending its water can force at least a pause. Algeria is the largest country in Africa, mostly Sahara, with its people and cities crowded on the Mediterranean coast, its economy resting on oil and gas, its water among the scarcest on earth, and its desert both a source of wealth and an advancing threat. Algeria is the largest country in Africa, the great majority of it Sahara, with its people and cities crowded on the narrow Mediterranean coast, its economy resting almost entirely on oil and gas exports, its water among the scarcest on earth and much of it non-renewable fossil water, and its desert both a source of wealth and an advancing threat to the oasis and the steppe. Its vast desert both a source of great wealth and an advancing threat to the oasis and the steppe alike. This guide will be honest that the gas economy is the state's foundation, so the extraction is driven hard; that the fracking and the oil and gas are state-led, so they cannot be openly defied but must be scrutinised and pressed on the water; that the desertification is severe and the Green Dam that was meant to hold it only partly succeeded; that the water is finite and the fossil aquifer non-renewable; that the political space is semi-closed and military-backed, so the work must be careful, within-system, and neutral on the politics; and that the one real precedent — the In Salah suspension — proved reversible; but it will show that the levers here — the water, the desert, the gas footprint, the coast, and the community that once stood at In Salah — are real, and, as In Salah proved, genuinely usable.

The Algerian story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Algerian, and it is what gives this guide its particular force. **Because the fracking and the extraction threaten a scarce and irreplaceable water the whole desert depends on, because the desertification can be met by the Green Dam and land restoration, because the gas footprint invites climate scrutiny and the Sahara offers a solar alternative, because the coast and the fossil aquifer can be defended, and because the community showed at In Salah that it can stand for its water, the levers run through the water and the desert: the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community.** That combination — the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a vast, dry, gas-exporting, semi-closed state, the strongest ground is the defence of the scarce water against the extraction, the holding-back of the desert, and the community capacity that In Salah proved real.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The gas is central, the extraction state-led, the desert advancing, the water finite, and the space semi-closed.**

The gas economy is the state's foundation and the extraction is driven hard; the fracking and the oil and gas are state-led and cannot be openly defied; the desertification is severe and the Green Dam only partly held; the water is finite and the fossil aquifer non-renewable; the political space is semi-closed and military-backed, and the In Salah precedent, real as it was, proved reversible. This guide does not pretend the gas is not central, or that the extraction can be openly defied, or that the space is open. What it shows is how, through the water, the desert, the gas footprint, the coast, and the community, Algerians — the oasis and desert communities, the scientists and technical people, the civil society, and the international frameworks — can scrutinise the extraction and defend the water, hold back the desert, and press the footprint, carefully and within the space that exists.

Most people who care about Algeria's environment do not know HOW to use the levers a vast, dry, gas-exporting, semi-closed state offers. They see the drilling in the Sahara, the aquifer drawn down, the desert advancing, the gas flared, the coast crowded — and either accept the extraction as the state's unchallengeable business, or despair of a semi-closed system, and rarely grasp the levers that work: the scarce water as the ground of opposition, the technical and scientific case, the community capacity In Salah proved, the international attention. The gap between the water defended and the water spent is here often a gap of method — the method of using the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community together.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Algerian reality as it is, which is a vast, largely Saharan, gas-exporting, semi-closed state where water is scarce and the desert advances. It is written for the person — in an oasis or desert community, among the scientists and technical people, in the country's constrained but real civil society, or among its international partners — who sees the extraction and the water and the desert and wants to know what can be done in a semi-closed and dry nation. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community — with the honest qualifiers that the gas is central, the extraction state-led, the desert advancing, the water finite, and the space semi-closed, so the work is careful, within-system, technical, community-based, and international, not open defiance. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used, because the Algerian case is particular and, in its In Salah precedent, more hopeful than many semi-closed states. It is for the person — in an oasis or desert community, among the scientists and technical people, in the country's constrained but real civil society, or among its international partners — willing to do the careful, water-grounded, technically-rigorous work of defending the scarce water and holding back the desert, rather than either accepting the extraction as the state's unchallengeable business or attempting the open political defiance that a semi-closed state forecloses. That is the right spirit here, because the levers that deliver — the scarce water, the community capacity In Salah proved, the technical rigour, the international attention — are genuinely available and, on the ground of the water, genuinely effective, as In Salah showed. Anyone who approaches Algeria by treating the extraction as untouchable will miss the real leverage the scarce water affords; anyone who approaches it through the water, the community, and the technical rigour, carefully and neutrally on the politics, can genuinely help defend the water that is life in the desert, as In Salah did. This guide is an honest map of that careful, water-grounded path.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a vast, dry, gas-exporting, semi-closed state:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the extraction, the water, and the framework)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build the evidence -- the harm and the water)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(build the community, technical, and scientific coalition)

STEP 4: REGULATORY, EXTRACTION & ENVIRONMENTAL-GOVERNANCE (extraction, desert, water)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it a water-and-desert cause)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of the harm and the threat to the water feeds the extraction scrutiny, the desert defence, and the footprint case at once; the community, technical, and scientific coalition organises; a water-protection case, a technical challenge, or an anti-desertification effort is both pressure and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still constrained — chance of scrutinising the extraction and defending the water and the desert.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Algeria's — a vast, dry, gas-exporting, semi-closed state — give a distinctive set:

- **The Saharan extraction.** The **oil, gas, and especially the shale-gas fracking** can be scrutinised and pressed on their threat to the scarce water — the distinctive lever.
- **The desert.** The **desertification** can be met by the Green Dam reforestation belt and land restoration.
- **The gas.** The **gas-superpower footprint and flaring** invite climate scrutiny, with the Sahara's solar as the alternative.
- **The coast.** The **water scarcity, the fossil aquifer, and the Mediterranean coast** can be defended through efficiency and conservation.
- **The community.** The **community capacity In Salah proved**, the technical and scientific people, and the constrained but real civic space are genuine.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that the gas is not central, or that the space is open. The gas is **central**; the extraction is **state-led**; the desert is **advancing**; the water is **finite**; and the space is **semi-closed**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it works through the water, the technical, the community, and the international while staying careful and neutral on the politics — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community — to scrutinise the extraction and defend the water and the desert, honestly acknowledging the central gas, the state-led extraction, the advancing desert, the finite water, and the semi-closed space.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that the levers run through the scarce water, the technical and scientific case, the community capacity In Salah proved, and the international attention, because in a semi-closed, military-backed state the extraction cannot be openly defied, but a fracking that threatens the water the whole desert depends on can be scrutinised and pressed on that ground. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides a project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community apply, because in Algeria a destructive project is met not by open confrontation with the state, but by defending the water, pressing the technical and scientific case, and drawing on the community capacity In Salah showed to be real.

The Levels of Decision

An Algerian project runs through a centralised, state-led, hydrocarbon-driven system.

The state and the energy company. The **government, the energy ministry, and the state oil-and-gas company** decide and drive the extraction, and are answerable, within the space, to the water concerns and the law.

The environment and water bodies. The **environment and water ministries and the anti-desertification and Green Dam programmes** are the state's own environmental framework — a real, if constrained, lever.

The scientific and technical institutions. The **universities, the scientists, and even the energy sector's own technical people** — some of whom led the In Salah concerns — study the water, the extraction, and the desert.

The community and civic space. The **oasis and desert communities, the constrained but real civil society, and the local associations** hold the stake and the capacity In Salah proved.

The regional and international frameworks. The **regional water and desertification bodies, the international climate and water frameworks, and the world's attention** carry the standards and the science a scarce-water desert nation invokes.

The Journey of a Project

An Algerian project — a fracking well in the Sahara, a gas flare, an aquifer drawn down, a desert advancing on a village — is met through the **Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community**. **The extraction and the water are where the harm is best met, and the desert, the gas, and the community are what carry the effort** — and using them together, through the water and the community, is the distinctive Algerian approach. The distinctive levers are the **Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what water, desert, or coast it harms, how it threatens the scarce water, and how the technical case, the community, and the international attention can be brought to bear**, because those are where a project can genuinely be met.

Follow the Project, the Water, and the Community

Behind a project stand the state, the energy company, the foreign partners, and the water, desert, and coast at stake. Trace who decides, who benefits, what is harmed, and — importantly here — **what water, desert, or coast is threatened, how the extraction threatens the scarce and fossil water, what environmental or water framework applies, and how the community, the technical people, and the international can act**. Two questions unlock most Algerian efforts: **What is harmed, and how does it threaten the scarce water?** and **Which lever — the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, the community — can meet it?** The water, the technical case, and the community capacity In Salah proved are, together, the heart of most such efforts here.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a project, because they are the levers. The **state and the energy company**; the **environment and water bodies**; the **scientific and technical institutions**; the **community and civic space**; and the **regional and international frameworks**. In Algeria, the **Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a

separate front, and a fracking well, a gas flare, a drawn-down aquifer, or an advancing desert can genuinely be met — through the water, the technical case, and the community — though, honestly, the gas is central, the extraction state-led, the desert advancing, the water finite, and the space semi-closed, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep working through the water, the technical, the community, and the international, carefully and neutrally on the politics.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging the central gas and the semi-closed space, even as the scarce water, the technical case, the community capacity In Salah proved, and the international attention give real, if constrained, leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how environmental efforts tend to go in vast, dry, gas-exporting, semi-closed states, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the harm can be **tied to the scarce water, the desert, or the footprint**, whether the **community and technical people** can be engaged, and whether the **international attention** can be brought to bear. Where the harm threatens the water and the community stands, the levers here are real, as In Salah proved; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the gas is central, the extraction state-led, and the space semi-closed.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Extraction / water case	30–50%	months–years	low	The extraction scrutinised, paused, or pressed on water
Desert / Green Dam	35–55%	years	low–moderate	The desert held back, restoration advanced
Gas / footprint	25–45%	years	low	The footprint and flaring pressed, solar advanced
Water / aquifer / coast	35–55%	years	low–moderate	The water defended, aquifer and coast protected
Community / technical route	35–55%	months–years	low	The community and technical voice mobilised
International / framework	30–50%	months–years	low	The world's attention and frameworks engaged
All levers together	30–50%	years	moderate	Extraction scrutinised; water and desert defended

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Algeria's real leverage is its scarce water and its community capacity: the **Saharan extraction**, the **desert**, the **gas**, the **coast**, and the **community**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the gas is **central**, the extraction **state-led**, the desert **advancing**, the water **finite**, and the space **semi-closed** — but the scarce water, the technical case, and the In Salah precedent make the levers here genuinely usable.

A note on cost and risk: most levers here — a water-protection case, a technical challenge, an anti-desertification effort — cost mainly organisation, knowledge, and persistence. The semi-closed, military-backed space counsels care: keep the work within-system, technical, and neutral on the politics, and protect those involved, for the In Salah movement, though real, met attempts to quell it. The scarce resources are **the technical and scientific capacity, the community and civic links, and the international connections** — much of it reachable through the water and environment bodies, the scientists, the desert communities, and the international water and desertification frameworks. This shapes where an Algerian effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are the water case and the technical rigour, the community capacity and standing, and the international connection — rather than the open political mobilisation that a semi-closed state forecloses — an effort's most valuable investments are in documenting the threat to the water, building the technical and scientific case, cultivating the community and its associations, and grounding the whole in the scarce water that unites and the In Salah precedent that guides. A credible, water-grounded, technically-rigorous effort that can marshal the aquifer science, mobilise the community, enlist the technical people, and stay careful and neutral on the politics can achieve real, if sometimes reversible, scrutiny and pause of the extraction, as In Salah did. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of the water case, the technical rigour, and the community and international standing — much of it reachable through the water and environment bodies, the scientists, the desert communities, and the international water and desertification frameworks. And because the water is scarce and irreplaceable, the water case is the most telling — as In Salah showed.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Algeria are **the desert and Green Dam, the water and aquifer defence, the community and technical route, and the extraction water-case** — used together, with the footprint and international levers alongside. The desert, water, and community levers show the ceiling: the desert held back, the scarce water defended, and the community mobilised — as In Salah showed — can achieve real, if partial, results. The central gas and the semi-closed space show the honest floor: open defiance is perilous and ineffective, and the extraction is state-led. Most Algerian efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to scrutinise the extraction and defend the water and desert in part — but that open defiance fails, and the surest result is that the harm is documented and pressed through the water case, the technical challenge, and the community.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The water case and the community capacity In Salah proved** — Algeria's distinctive levers; the scarce water and the proven mobilisation.
2. **The desert and the Green Dam** — the holding-back of the Sahara.
3. **The technical and scientific challenge** — the rigour that led the In Salah concerns.

4. **The gas footprint and the solar alternative** — the climate scrutiny and the desert's sun.

5. **The documented harm and water threat** — the evidence that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The water is scarce and irreplaceable** — the strongest ground of opposition. **In Salah proved the community can stand** — a real, if reversible, precedent. **The technical people can lead** — scientists and even energy professionals raised the In Salah concerns. **The desert can be held** — through the Green Dam and restoration. **But the gas is central and the space semi-closed** — so the work is careful, water-based, and within-system. The through-line: **document the harm and the threat to the water; scrutinise the extraction and the fracking on the water; hold back the desert through the Green Dam and restoration; press the gas footprint and advance the solar; defend the water, the aquifer, and the coast; use the community, technical, and international channels; and stay careful and neutral on the politics** — because an effort that does can genuinely scrutinise the extraction and defend the water and the desert, as In Salah showed, while being honest that the gas is central, the extraction state-led, and the space semi-closed.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm — and the leverage, which here runs through the scarce water, the technical case, and the community. Vague concern goes nowhere, and open defiance is perilous; an effort aimed at "this project threatening this water, desert, or coast, which the water case, the technical challenge, or the community can meet" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. What is harmed? This is the first question here. What **water, desert, or coast** is harmed — the fossil aquifer, the oasis water, the desert, the Mediterranean coast, the air.

2. How does it threaten the water? How the project threatens the **scarce and often fossil water** — the fracking's huge water use and contamination risk, the aquifer draw-down — for water is the ground of opposition.

3. Is it extraction, desert, or water? Whether the matter is one of the **Saharan extraction**, the **desert and desertification**, or the **water, aquifer, and coast** — for each has its levers.

4. What framework applies? What **water, environmental, anti-desertification, or hydrocarbon framework**, national or international, the project touches.

5. How can the community and technical people act? How the **community, the scientists and technical people, and the international** can act — carefully, within the space, as In Salah showed.

A Worked Example

Suppose a shale-gas fracking operation is being pressed into a stretch of the Sahara near an oasis, drawing on and risking the fossil aquifer the community depends on for its water.

Working the five questions: **what is harmed? How does it threaten the water? Is it extraction, desert, or water? What framework applies?** And how can the community and technical people act? The driver is the fracking and the water threat, with the water case, the technical challenge, and the community as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the fracking is the state's business and nothing can be said" to a real effort: document the water use and the contamination risk to the fossil aquifer; press the water-protection case and demand transparency and independent study; draw on the technical and scientific people; and mobilise the oasis community, as In Salah did — all carefully and within the space. That is a workable effort suited to Algeria — one that scrutinises the extraction and defends the water through the water case, the technical challenge, and the community, as In Salah proved possible. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight in a vast, dry, gas-exporting, semi-closed state: they turn what might seem an unchallengeable state enterprise — the extraction the whole economy rests on, driven by the state and its foreign partners — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that rests on the scarce water, the technical rigour, and the community capacity In Salah proved, rather than on an open defiance the semi-closed space forecloses. The harm becomes a documentable threat to the aquifer, the oasis, or the coast. The water threat becomes the ground of opposition, unifying and undeniable. The category becomes the extraction, the desert, or the water, each with its levers. The framework becomes the water, environmental, or anti-desertification standard. And the channels become the community, the technical people, and the international, careful and neutral on the politics. That translation — from a seemingly unchallengeable state enterprise into a set of specific water-grounded, community-based, technically-rigorous actions — is the first and most important thing an Algerian effort does, because it moves the fight from the resignation of the state's unassailable business onto the firm ground of the scarce water, where, as In Salah proved, a desert community and its technical allies have a genuine, if constrained, voice.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, distinctively, the decisive evidence is the harm and the threat to the scarce water, which is the ground on which even a semi-closed state can be pressed, as In Salah showed. A water body, an environment ministry, the scientists, the community, and the international frameworks all move on evidence — and for Algeria, a clear record of the harm and the threat to the irreplaceable water is precisely what a careful effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Harm, and the Water

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project and the harm** — the fracking, the flare, the aquifer draw-down, the desert advance — and, decisively here, **the water, desert, or coast it threatens**: the fossil aquifer, the oasis water, the desert, the coast, on which the community and the desert life depend. Establish exactly **what the project is, what it harms, and how it threatens the scarce water**, because the harm-against-the-water is the case's foundation and the ground of opposition.

Layer 2: The Harm, the Science, and the Water Threat

Document the harm with the science. Establish the **environmental harm** — the water use and contamination, the aquifer depletion, the desert degradation, the flaring — and its **threat to the scarce water** — drawing on **the water and aquifer science, the extraction and fracking data, the desertification studies, and the technical expertise**. This harm-and-water evidence turns the concern into a documented threat to the irreplaceable water, which is the strongest and most defensible ground here.

Layer 3: The Case, the Framework, the Channel, and the Care

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **harm** threaten the water, breach the environmental or water frameworks, or endanger the aquifer? What **framework** — water, environmental, anti-desertification, hydrocarbon, national or international — applies? Which **community, technical, or international channels** will act? And how will the work stay **careful, within-system, and neutral on the politics**? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case grounded in the water and the science. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented harm, a threatened water, an applicable framework, and a careful channel are exactly what let an Algerian effort scrutinise the extraction and defend the water — as In Salah did. Build it well, and the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community become the effort's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: because Algeria's water scarcity, its Saharan aquifers, and the fracking controversy have drawn sustained scientific and international attention — from hydrologists studying the fossil aquifer systems, from the technical experts who analysed the fracking's water demands during the In Salah episode, from the desertification and Green Dam research, and from the international water and climate bodies — a great deal of the necessary evidence already exists and is genuinely obtainable, and the water threat in particular is well documented. The vast water use of each fracking well, the finiteness of the fossil aquifer, the contamination risks, and the advance of the desert are all matters of established study. This means an effort here can often build its water case substantially from that existing record, and ground it in the technical rigour that led the In Salah concerns, rather than from scratch. Building this layer well therefore means marshalling that existing water and technical record — the aquifer science, the fracking water-demand data, the desertification studies — and joining it to the community's own knowledge of its water, so that the case rests on the solid, unifying, and well-documented ground of the scarce water.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here much of it lives in the water and aquifer science, the extraction and fracking data, the desertification studies, and the deep knowledge of the desert communities. Here is where the material tends to live in an Algerian effort, and how to get it — with the **harm**, the **water**, the **science**, and the **framework** at the center, and care throughout. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Project, Harm, and Water Record

Start with the project and the water. **The project documentation, the environmental studies, and the water and aquifer records** establish the project and the threat; the distinctive strengths here are the **scarce, fossil water** whose threat is the ground of opposition, and the **technical and scientific record**, much of it produced by Algeria's own capable institutions. Establish the **project, the harm, and the threat to the water**, drawing on the project and water records. Establish exactly **what is planned, what it harms, and how it threatens the irreplaceable water**, because a threat to scarce fossil water is the strongest ground.

The Harm, Science, and Water Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **harm evidence** — the fracking water use and contamination, the aquifer depletion, the desert degradation, the flaring — and the **science and the water threat** — drawing on **the water and aquifer science, the extraction and fracking data, the desertification studies, and the technical expertise**. This harm-and-water evidence is what turns the concern into a documented threat to the scarce water.

The Framework, Water, and Anti-Desertification Record

Document the levers of the frameworks. Gather the record of **the water and environmental frameworks and the aquifer's protection; the anti-desertification and Green Dam programmes; and the international water, climate, and desertification frameworks and the shared-aquifer agreements**. A community and its allies that understand the water frameworks, the Green Dam, and the international standards hold the levers that press even a state-led extraction on the ground of the water.

The Community, Technical, and International Record

Document the wider levers. Gather the record of the **oasis and desert communities and the local associations that mobilised at In Salah; the scientists, technical people, and even energy professionals who raised the concerns; and the international water, desertification, and climate partners**. A community joined to the technical people and the international frameworks holds levers that reach from the oasis to the world's water and desert science — as In Salah showed.

The People, the Care, and the Neutrality

Finally, map the human terrain and the care it requires. Who is affected — the **oasis and desert communities, the farmers and pastoralists, the coastal people, and the future generations** — and who can act: the **communities, the technical people, the civil society, and the international**, carefully, within the space. And how does the effort **stay careful, within-system, and neutral on the politics**? An Algerian effort is advanced through the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community — so map that coalition deliberately, ground it in the water, keep it neutral on the politics, and let care govern every step, as the In Salah movement had to.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step draws on a real, proven strength, because Algeria's In Salah movement showed that even in a semi-closed, military-backed state, a community defending its water can mobilise widely and force a pause. The "opposition" that works joins the oasis and desert communities to the technical and scientific people and the international, pressing on the water and staying careful and neutral on the politics. The task is to build a coalition — of communities, technical people, civil society, and international partners — that scrutinises the extraction and defends the water and the desert.

Why the Community-Technical-and-International Coalition Is Decisive

In Algeria, the coalition that can act joins the communities to the technical and scientific people and the international, because a semi-closed state responds, on the ground of the scarce water, to broad community mobilisation, rigorous technical challenge, and international attention — as In Salah proved. That coalition supplies what a careful effort runs on: the oasis and desert communities who hold the stake and the moral force of their water, the scientists and technical people — even energy professionals — whose rigour led the In Salah concerns, the constrained but real civil society, and the international frameworks. When communities, technical people, and the international press together on the water, they become a genuine force, as In Salah showed. **A coalition that joins community, technical rigour, and the international on the ground of the water here is not a weak or borrowed thing but a proven strength — the real foundation of an Algerian effort, defending the water and scrutinising the extraction as the In Salah movement did.** This is worth dwelling on, because Algeria offers something few states in this series can: a proven, recent precedent of exactly this kind of coalition succeeding, at least for a time, even under a semi-closed and military-backed system. When the fracking came to In Salah, it was not a single group but a

coalition that rose — the oasis community and its associations, the scientists and technical people, even oil-and-gas professionals who understood the water risk and called for transparent study, and, further out, neighbouring desert towns and the wider country and international attention. They were bound together not by a political programme, which would have been perilous, but by the one thing that unites a desert people beyond all division: the scarce water on which their survival depends. That coalition, grounded in the water and led in part by technical rigour, forced a state-led project backed by powerful interests to suspend, at least for a time. The task, therefore, is to build that same kind of coalition — community, technical rigour, and the international, united on the ground of the water — because it is not a theoretical construction but a proven one, and because the water that unites it is a ground on which even a semi-closed state can be pressed, as In Salah showed.

Finding the Coalition

Begin with those the project touches and those who can act — the **oasis and desert communities, the local associations, the scientists and technical people, and the civil society** — for the In Salah precedent shows this coalition can be built, carefully. Widen to all who share the water and the desert. Name the shared stake — **our water, our oasis, our desert, and our children's survival** — because in a desert nation the water is life itself, as In Salah understood. Frame the effort around defending the water and the desert, on the technical and community ground, carefully and neutrally on the politics. There is real power, and real safety, in framing the cause this way, because the water is a ground that unites rather than divides, that the state itself cannot easily deny, and that keeps the effort clear of the political confrontation that would be both perilous and self-defeating in a semi-closed state. A cause framed around the politics or the regime would, in Algeria's constrained space, invite suppression and forfeit the broad coalition; a cause framed around the scarce, irreplaceable water — the survival of the oasis, the protection of the fossil aquifer, the holding-back of the desert — unites the community, the technical people, and even those within the system who understand the water risk, as In Salah's coalition showed. This framing is not only the safer one; it is also the truer one, because in a desert nation the water genuinely is the heart of the matter, the resource whose loss is irreversible and whose defence is a matter of survival, not politics. An effort that names this frame precisely — the water and the desert, carefully and neutrally on the politics — stands on the strongest, safest, and most unifying ground the Algerian situation affords, the very ground on which In Salah stood.

Coalition-Building, Through Community, Rigour, and the International

A coalition allied is stronger than any single actor, and in Algeria it is built through community, technical rigour, and the international. Reach to the **oasis and desert communities and local associations**; the **scientists, technical people, and professionals**; the **constrained but real civil society**; the **water and environment bodies**; and the **international water, desertification, and climate frameworks**. Frame the coalition around the water, the desert, the extraction, and the coast. Build breadth through the community and the technical people, carefully and neutrally on the politics — for the coalition's strength, as In Salah showed, is the union of the community's stake in its water and the rigour of the technical people.

Sustaining the Effort

Algerian efforts are sustained through the community, the technical rigour, and the international. Keep the coalition **informed, connected, and careful**, grounded in the water; mark real steps — a fracking paused, a study demanded, a desert held, an aquifer protected, a flare reduced. And keep the effort grounded in the water and the desert, which unite and endure, and neutral on the politics. The effort that lasts is the one that grounds itself in the water, joins the community to the technical people and the international, stays careful

and neutral on the politics, and draws on the capacity In Salah proved.

STEP 4: REGULATORY, EXTRACTION & ENVIRONMENTAL-GOVERNANCE CHALLENGES — THE SAHARAN EXTRACTION, THE DESERT, AND THE WATER

This is where an Algerian effort is realistically advanced — not through open defiance, which is perilous, but through the **scrutiny of the Saharan extraction on the ground of the water, the holding-back of the desert, and the defence of the water and the coast**, grounded in the technical case, the community, and the international. Here the extraction, desert, and water levers come together, because in Algeria a project that threatens the scarce water can be pressed through those levers, carefully, as In Salah showed.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but work within a gas-central, state-led, semi-closed system**. The extraction scrutiny is **real on the ground of the water but the gas is central and state-led**; the desert defence is **genuine but the desertification is severe and the Green Dam only partly held**; the water defence is **strong because the water is scarce, but the fossil aquifer is finite**; and the space is **semi-closed**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the extraction scrutinised and paused, the desert held back, the water and aquifer defended, the footprint pressed, and the community mobilised** — real outcomes, if partial and sometimes reversible, as the In Salah suspension proved. Enter this front clear-eyed: the extraction, the desert, and the water are Algeria's distinctive levers, strongest when the **threat to the scarce water is clearly documented** — but the gas is central, the extraction state-led, and the space semi-closed.

The Saharan Extraction and the Water

The first front is the extraction and the water. The **oil, gas, and especially the shale-gas fracking pressed into the Sahara**, which consumes vast quantities of the scarce water and risks contaminating the fossil aquifer the desert depends on, can be **scrutinised and pressed on the ground of the water** — demanding transparency, independent study of the water use and contamination risk, respect for the aquifer, and, where the risk to the irreplaceable water is grave, a moratorium, as the In Salah movement sought and briefly won. Use the Saharan extraction and the water, because the threat to the scarce, fossil, irreplaceable water is the strongest and most unifying ground of opposition — as In Salah proved, a community defending its water against fracking can force even a state-led project to pause, at least for a time. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this extraction-and-water front, honestly, for it is the most distinctive lever an Algerian effort holds. Its power is real and proven: the threat that fracking poses to the scarce, fossil, irreplaceable water is a ground that unites a desert people across all division, that the technical evidence strongly supports, and that even a semi-closed state cannot easily dismiss — and at In Salah it forced a state-led project, backed by powerful and foreign interests, to suspend. Its limits are equally real: the suspension proved reversible, the gas economy the state depends on drives the extraction hard, and the state has periodically revived its shale-gas ambitions. Understanding both means using the extraction-and-water front for what it does best — grounding the opposition in the undeniable threat to the irreplaceable water, demanding transparency and independent study and a moratorium where the risk is grave, and drawing on the community and technical coalition In Salah proved — while recognising that the water case must be pressed again and again, for the gas economy will keep returning to the Sahara, and each pause must be renewed.

The Desert and the Green Dam

The second front is the desert. The **advancing Sahara and the degrading steppe** can be met through the **Green Dam — the great reforestation belt raised to hold back the desert — and the wider land-restoration and anti-desertification frameworks**, revived, strengthened, and joined to the international Great Green Wall effort. Press the desert and the Green Dam, because holding back the desert is a cause the state itself professes and the international frameworks support, and strengthening the Green Dam and the land restoration defends the land, the water, and the future against a desert that advances on the oasis and the steppe alike.

The Gas, the Water, and the Coast

The third front is the gas and the water. The **gas-superpower footprint and the flaring** can be pressed through the **climate and transition scrutiny and the enormous solar alternative the Sahara offers**, and the **scarce water, the finite fossil aquifer, and the crowded Mediterranean coast** can be defended through **water efficiency, sustainable desalination, aquifer protection, and coastal conservation**. Press the gas, the water, and the coast, because the flaring and the footprint invite the climate scrutiny and the Sahara's sun offers the alternative, and because the finite water and the crowded coast are the desert nation's most precious and pressured resources. Pursued together — the extraction, the desert, and the water — these fronts are how an Algerian effort scrutinises the extraction and defends the water and the desert, through the water case, the community, and the international, carefully and neutrally on the politics. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Algeria's particular situation, for they are bound together by the water. The extraction front scrutinises the fracking and the oil and gas precisely on the ground of the water they consume and endanger. The desert front holds back the Sahara whose advance the same drying and degradation accelerate. And the gas-and-water front presses the footprint toward the Sahara's own sun and defends the finite aquifer and the crowded coast. Each covers the others' reach: the extraction at the level of the water it risks, the desert at the level of the land it claims, and the gas and coast at the level of the footprint and the finite water. And each strengthens the others, for the water the extraction endangers is the same the desert's advance threatens and the aquifer holds, the solar that would replace the flaring would spare the water the fracking consumes, and the community that defends the water defends the desert and the coast alike. An effort that grasps this mutual reinforcement, and pursues each front together on the ground of the water, makes the fullest use of the several water, desert, and community levers that a vast, dry, gas-exporting state uniquely presents — and that In Salah showed can be pressed.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of harm and water-threat becomes different arguments for the state, the water bodies, the technical people, the community, and the international frameworks. Translate deliberately, and always carefully and grounded in the water.

For the State and Energy Bodies

The state and energy bodies respond to **the water, the law, and the stability**. Frame the harm as a threat to the scarce water and to the stability of the desert communities: here is the project, the water it threatens, the aquifer at risk, the unrest that water threats provoke. Give them the documented water threat, and press for transparency, independent study, and respect for the water. Make it concrete: *here is the threat to the irreplaceable water, here is what In Salah showed, here is the study and the safeguard that would protect*

both the water and the peace. This is the argument a state mindful of its water and its stability must weigh.

For the Water and Environment Bodies

The water and environment bodies respond to **the water, the aquifer, and the desert**. Frame the harm as a matter for the water and the anti-desertification frameworks: here is the threat to the aquifer, the desert, the frameworks they administer. Give them the science, and press for protection and enforcement. A water body charged with the scarce water can act on the ground of that water.

For the Technical and Scientific Community

The technical and scientific community respond to **the data, the rigour, and the water**. Frame the harm as a technical and scientific matter: here is the water use, the contamination risk, the aquifer science, the measured threat. Give them the data and the technical case, and enlist their rigour and voice — for at In Salah, it was scientists and technical people who led. Algeria's capable technical community, engaged carefully, is a genuine force.

For the Community and International Frameworks

The community and international frameworks respond to **the water, the survival, and the desert**. Translate the file into the story of a scarce water and a desert life threatened: here is the oasis, the fossil aquifer, the fracking, the survival at stake. Frame it as the defence of the water that is life in the desert. Keep it accurate and grounded in the community's stake; and speak to the world's water and desertification concern. In Salah showed how powerfully this frame can carry.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, ground it in the water, and stay careful and neutral on the politics. Your credibility rests on the real harm and the real threat to the scarce water — the water case and the science, not the political; and care and neutrality are essential in a semi-closed, military-backed state, as the In Salah movement had to observe. State the harm precisely, tie it to the water, the desert, or the footprint, and press through the community, the technical people, and the international. An effort that is precise, water-grounded, and technically rigorous is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches, and far safer than one that strays into open political defiance.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, though the domestic space is semi-closed, the water-and-desert story resonates, and In Salah showed that a Saharan community's stand for its water can command national and international attention. The story — a desert people defending the scarce water beneath the sand against the fracking — is powerful, if told carefully and grounded in the water.

Why Media Matters

The state, the water bodies, the technical people, and the world behave differently when the harm and the threat to the water are visible. Media does three things here: it **informs and connects the community and the technical people**, it **raises the stakes** for a state mindful of the water and the stability, and it **reaches the international water, desertification, and climate frameworks and the world's attention** — as In Salah's story reached far beyond the Sahara. The domestic space is semi-closed and the politics sensitive, so the media effort runs through **careful domestic communication, the community's and technical**

people's voices, international coverage, and rigorous, water-grounded documentation, staying neutral on the politics.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the water and the desert. The strongest frame is concrete and resonant: *a desert community defending the scarce, fossil water beneath the sand — the water that is life in the Sahara — against a fracking that would consume and endanger it*. Put the water and the desert life first, because the threat to the irreplaceable water in the driest of lands is a powerful, unifying, and internationally resonant story, as In Salah proved. Keep it scrupulously accurate and grounded in the water and the community; and stay neutral on the politics. The Algerian story is powerful because the water is scarce, the desert life real, and the community's stand — as In Salah showed — genuine.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience. **Careful domestic communication and community networks** for the desert communities; **international coverage and the water and desertification forums** for the world; **scientific and technical channels** for the water and the aquifer; and **community and local networks** for the oasis. Because the water story is resonant and In Salah showed its reach, both the careful domestic and the international channels can carry it, kept water-grounded and neutral on the politics — the scarce water and the desert life are the story's power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, careful, water-grounded, and neutral on the politics — the aim is defending the water and the desert, not political confrontation, and never anything that could be read as such or endanger anyone in a semi-closed state, as the In Salah movement had to be mindful. Frame the story around the water, the desert, the extraction, and the coast, and handle the state, the military, the politics, and the foreign companies factually and neutrally, keeping the focus on the environment and the water. And sustain the story across the slow work. Above all, let the scarce water, the desert life, and the community's stand carry the story, because that is where an Algerian effort is strongest and safest — as In Salah showed.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real water threat, keep it factual and water-grounded, and stay careful and neutral on the politics. Here the water, the technical case, and the community, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — [project] and the water

To [energy / water / environment authority],

I am writing on behalf of [community / association] regarding [the project] and its effects on [the aquifer / oasis water / desert]. In the interest of protecting our scarce water, I respectfully request the **environmental and water-use studies**, the **aquifer and contamination assessments**, and the **relevant permits** for the project.

I would be grateful for a response within the legal period.

Respectfully,

[Name, community / association, contact]

8B: The Extraction / Water Case

Subject: [The fracking / extraction] and the threat to our water

To [energy authority / environment ministry],

The [fracking / extraction] at [location] would consume vast quantities of our scarce water and risks contaminating the fossil aquifer our community depends on. We respectfully urge transparency, independent study, respect for the aquifer, and, given the grave risk to our irreplaceable water, a moratorium pending that study. We attach the water evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: The Desert / Green Dam Case

Subject: Holding back the desert at [location]

To [environment / agriculture / anti-desertification authority],

The desert advances on [location], and the land degrades. We respectfully urge the strengthening and revival of the Green Dam and the land-restoration programmes to hold back the desert and protect the land and water. We attach the assessment.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: The Gas / Footprint Case

Subject: Flaring, the footprint, and the solar alternative at [location]

To [energy / environment authority],

The [flaring / footprint] at [location] wastes resources and harms the air, even as our Sahara offers vast solar potential. We respectfully urge the reduction of flaring and the advancement of the solar alternative. We attach the data.

Respectfully,

[Name, contact]

8E: The Water / Aquifer / Coast Case

Subject: Protecting our water at [location]

To [water authority / environment ministry],

Our scarce water — [the fossil aquifer / the desalination supply / the coast] at [location] — faces [the threat]. We respectfully urge its protection through efficiency, aquifer protection, sustainable desalination, and coastal conservation. We attach the water evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: To an International or Regional Framework

Subject: The scarce water and the Saharan extraction in Algeria

Dear [international / regional water / desertification body],

We write regarding [the threat to the fossil aquifer / the desert] from [the extraction / desertification]. We respectfully seek your scientific engagement and the water and desertification frameworks' attention, in keeping with the shared-aquifer and international standards. We provide the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: A desert people defending the water beneath the sand

Dear [journalist / editor],

In the Algerian Sahara, a desert community is defending the scarce, fossil water beneath the sand — the water that is life here — against a fracking that would consume and endanger it, as In Salah once did. There is a strong, resonant, internationally significant story here, and we can provide the water science, the community's voices, and the technical case.

Sincerely,

[Name, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our water is our life — let us defend it

Dear neighbours,

Our water — the fossil water beneath our desert, the life of our oasis — faces [the fracking / the extraction], which would consume and endanger it. But In Salah showed that a desert community defending its water can stand and be heard — and together, communities, technical people, and all who depend on this water, by documenting the threat, pressing the water case, and holding back the desert, we can defend our water. Please join us, carefully and grounded in our water: share what you know, and add your voice.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a project is acute — a fracking rig arriving, a well spudding, an aquifer being tapped, a flare lit — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest here, which means the water case, the community, and the technical challenge, kept careful and neutral on the politics.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what is harmed, and how does it threaten the scarce water**. Identify the immediate harm — **a fracking rig, a well, an aquifer tap, a flare** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **community and local associations, the technical and scientific people, and the water**

and environment bodies at once, because in Algeria the water case, the community, and the technical challenge are the fastest routes to real leverage — and keep careful and neutral on the politics from the start, as In Salah did.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The water case** can be raised at once against a threat to the aquifer. **The community** can mobilise quickly, as In Salah showed. **The technical people** can challenge fast. **The international water and desertification frameworks** can be engaged. These outpace the slower work of the deep desert and footprint reform — which must follow — because the water case, the community, and the technical challenge can be brought to bear immediately. Above all, if a fracking threatens the scarce aquifer, raise the water case and demand a study and a moratorium fast, because the threat to the irreplaceable water is the ground on which even a state-led project can be paused, as In Salah proved.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can mobilise the community and the technical people fast, on the ground of the water. Reach immediately to the **community and local associations, the technical and scientific people, and the water bodies**, keeping careful and neutral on the politics. A coalition raising the water case, mobilising the community, and enlisting the technical people is the most a rapid Algerian effort can do — and, as In Salah showed, it can be considerable. Speed favours the prepared: know the water threat, the aquifer, and the frameworks before the crisis breaks, and ground the effort in the water.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the field is tilted by an economy founded on the gas and oil the state must extract, by a centralised, military-backed, semi-closed system where open defiance is perilous, by a north-south divide that leaves the desert communities marginalised, by the involvement of powerful foreign companies, and by a civic space that, though it produced In Salah, is constrained and was pressed to quell it. Name it plainly, because pretending the gas is not central, or that the space is open, or that the In Salah precedent was permanent, would be false — but note that the scarce water, the community capacity In Salah proved, the technical rigour, and the international attention make even this tilted field one where careful, water-grounded work can move.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The economy rests on the gas and oil** — the extraction is the state's foundation. **The system is centralised and semi-closed** — open defiance is perilous. **The desert communities are marginalised** — a north-south divide. **Powerful foreign companies are involved** — in the extraction. **And the civic space is constrained** — In Salah met attempts to quell it. But **the scarce water, the community capacity, the technical rigour, and the international attention** are real levers. This is a tilt of a rent economy, a semi-closed system, and a marginalised south, worked through the water case, the community, the technical rigour, and the international, carefully and neutrally on the politics.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers of the water, the community, and the technical rigour. Lean on the **scarce water**, the strongest and most unifying ground; the **community capacity In Salah proved**; the **technical and scientific rigour** that led those concerns; the **international water and desertification**

frameworks; and the **Green Dam and the solar alternative**, causes the state itself professes. Meet the state-led extraction not with open defiance but with the documented threat to the irreplaceable water and the demand for study and safeguard. And build the community and technical coalition over time, because for a semi-closed state these accumulate into real, if constrained, pressure — as In Salah showed. A field tilted by a rent economy and a semi-closed system is worked through the water, the community, and the technical rigour, carefully and neutrally on the politics, not through an open defiance the space makes perilous.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little lasting change — the fracking may proceed, the aquifer may be tapped, the desert may advance — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the gas is central and the In Salah suspension itself proved reversible. But even here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **harm was documented, the water case made, the community mobilised, the desert defended, and the world engaged** — and every fracking paused, every study won, every aquifer protected, every desert held makes a real difference and builds the water-grounded pressure and the community capacity a semi-closed state cannot forever ignore. Press, carefully and on the water, for the water and the desert; even if a project proceeds, the water case you built and the community you mobilised will shape the next, as In Salah's stand still shapes the debate — for the threat to the irreplaceable water is a ground that does not go away.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Algeria, alongside the honest tilt of a rent economy and a semi-closed state, there is a real dimension of capture, because the hydrocarbon sector has long been marked by opaque contracts and rent-seeking, the extraction decisions have too often served the connected and the foreign partners rather than the communities whose water they risk, and the benefits of the gas have not reached the marginalised desert south. The harm here is partly the capture of the extraction, the water, and their benefits by the connected. The response runs through the transparency, the technical scrutiny, and the international frameworks that can reach it.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

Here the capture is bound up with a rent economy and a semi-closed state, and its marks are specific: **opaque hydrocarbon contracts and decisions, the extraction serving the connected and the foreign partners over the communities, the benefits bypassing the marginalised desert south, and the water risked for private and connected gain**. The task is to document it rigorously and reach it through the transparency and the technical and international channels, relying on the hydrocarbon and contract records, the technical data, and the international transparency frameworks, and keeping strictly to the environmental and the water, neutral on the politics. And note that the capture of the extraction and the water is inseparable from the harm to them, and from the marginalisation of the desert communities.

Responding to Capture — Through Transparency and the Technical

Where the capture is real, the response runs through the transparency and the technical and international channels. Use the **transparency of the hydrocarbon contracts and decisions** to expose the opacity and the capture. Use the **technical and scientific scrutiny** to measure the water threat behind the extraction. Use the **international transparency and water frameworks** to reach it. And use the **community's stake and voice** — grounded in the water, as In Salah's was — to press it. Document rigorously, keep strictly to the environmental and the water, and stay careful and neutral on the politics, for in a semi-closed state the record must be technical and the people protected. Route the effort through the transparency, the technical

scrutiny, and the international — never through open political confrontation.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note matters here. Algeria is a semi-closed, military-backed state where open political defiance is perilous and the In Salah movement, though real, met attempts to quell it, so this work must be careful, within-system, water-grounded, and neutral on the politics. Favour the **community, technical, water-body, and international channels** over any open confrontation; protect those involved, and be mindful that the space is constrained and the south marginalised; frame the work strictly around the water, the desert, and the extraction, never around the politics; and handle the state, the military, the foreign companies, and the north-south divide factually and neutrally. Care here is essential but not paralysing: the In Salah movement showed that a careful, water-grounded, community-based effort can mobilise widely and be heard even in this space — so work carefully, ground everything in the water, stay neutral on the politics, and let the scarce water and the community's stake, as In Salah did, carry the effort.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all grounded in the water, careful, and neutral on the politics. Here is how they fit into a single Algerian effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the harm-and-water file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the community-technical-and-international coalition, organises the communities, the technical people, and the international. **Regulatory, extraction, and environmental-governance** work scrutinises the extraction, holds back the desert, and defends the water. **Media**, careful and water-grounded, carries the water-and-desert cause. The harm-and-water feeds all five at once — a documented water threat is a water case, a technical challenge, a community mobilisation, and an international appeal together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, grounded in the water and the community, they compound into real scrutiny of the extraction and defence of the water — as In Salah showed.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the harm and the threat to the water; identify the extraction, the desert, the gas, and the coast; build the community-technical-and-international coalition and begin documentation, carefully. **Middle (months 2–18):** scrutinise the extraction on the water; hold back the desert through the Green Dam; press the footprint and the solar; and defend the water and the coast. **Later (months and years):** see the extraction scrutinised or paused, the desert held, the water defended, and the community mobilised. An Algerian effort works through the water, the community, and the technical rigour, and its fruits — the extraction pressed, the water defended — are gradual and sometimes reversible, as In Salah proved; pace it accordingly, ground it in the water, and stay careful and neutral on the politics.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm and the threat to the water; scrutinise the extraction and the fracking on the water; hold back the desert through the Green Dam and restoration; press the gas footprint and advance the solar; defend the water, the aquifer, and the coast; use the community, technical, and international channels; and stay careful**

and neutral on the politics. The coalition that presses all five, grounded in the water and drawing on the capacity In Salah proved, is the one that can genuinely scrutinise the extraction and defend the water and the desert — the kind of result a vast, dry, gas-exporting, semi-closed state allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive project in Algeria is genuinely challenging, and bound up with an economy founded on the gas and oil the state must extract, with a centralised, semi-closed, military-backed system, with a marginalised desert south, and with a civic space that produced In Salah but was pressed to quell it, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: the gas is central, the extraction state-led, the desert advancing, the water finite, and the space semi-closed. And yet the effort is far from futile — indeed In Salah proved it real — because the fracking and the extraction threaten a scarce and irreplaceable water the whole desert depends on, because the desertification can be met by the Green Dam, because the gas footprint invites climate scrutiny and the Sahara offers solar, because the coast and the fossil aquifer can be defended, and because the community showed it can stand for its water; and those levers of the Saharan extraction, the desert, the gas, the coast, and the community are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The water is scarce and irreplaceable — the strongest ground of opposition, as In Salah proved. The community can stand for its water — a real, if reversible, precedent. The technical people and the desert can both be marshalled. But the gas is central, the extraction state-led, and the space semi-closed.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive levers of water and community, and the honest weight of a gas-central, semi-closed state.

Above all, keep the discipline that gives these efforts their force. Document the harm and the threat to the water. Scrutinise the extraction and the fracking on the water. Hold back the desert through the Green Dam and restoration. Press the gas footprint and advance the solar. Defend the water, the aquifer, and the coast. Use the community, technical, and international channels. And stay careful and neutral on the politics — because in a vast, dry, gas-exporting, semi-closed state, an effort that scrutinises the extraction and defends the water and the desert through the scarce water, the community capacity In Salah proved, the technical rigour, and the international, carried carefully and neutrally on the politics, is the one that is both effective and just.

Algeria is a vast land that is mostly Sahara, its people gathered on the Mediterranean coast, its wealth drawn from the gas and oil beneath the desert, its water among the scarcest on earth and much of it fossil water that will not return, its great desert both a source of riches and a threat that advances on the oasis and the steppe. This guide has hidden none of that, nor pretended that the gas is not central, or that the space is open, or that the In Salah victory was permanent, and there is no lasting landmark victory to promise you. But the water is scarce and irreplaceable, and there, on the ground of the water, even a state-led extraction can be scrutinised and pressed; the desert can be held back through the Green Dam; and the community, as In Salah proved, can stand for its water and be heard. Those are the levers, and they are real: the scarce water, defended as the life it is; the desert, held back by the Green Dam and restoration; the footprint, pressed toward the Sahara's own sun; and the community and technical rigour that at In Salah forced even a state-led fracking to pause. There is no open defiance in a semi-closed state, and no permanent victory over an economy built on the desert's gas; this guide has said so throughout, and counselled care and neutrality on the politics. But the water and the desert and the oases of Algeria are worth every careful, water-grounded effort, the levers that run through the scarce water and the community are real, and the patient, technical, community-based work of documenting the threat, pressing the water case, and holding back the desert is one that Algerians — the desert communities, the technical people, and their international

partners — can genuinely do, as In Salah showed, and defend the water that is life in the driest of lands. So can you.